

CHAPTER ONE

Haraway's Dog

Stories are much bigger than ideologies. In that is our hope.

—DONNA HARAWAY, *The Companion Species Manifesto*, 17

Want a different ethic? Tell a different story.

—THOMAS KING, *The Truth about Stories*, 164

IN THE WINTER OF 2014, I taught a seminar at the University of Alberta on research-creation. The seminar, *Debates in Art and/as Research*, began with the reading of two texts, neither of which made obvious sense to my students given the topic, as neither refers explicitly to research-creation, nor to arts-based research, nor, indeed, to “art” very much at all, but that instead speak to intertwined sites of Indigenous and ecological genocide: Thomas King’s *The Truth about Stories* and Donna Haraway’s *The Companion Species Manifesto: Dogs, People, and Significant Otherness*.

The Truth about Stories is a small volume of transcribed lectures by King, a novelist and broadcaster who was invited, in 2003, to deliver the annual Canadian Broadcasting Corporation (CBC) Massey Lectures.¹ In these lectures King speaks to the textures, effects, and logics of colonial violence, and to the promise of decolonized futures. He does so through

the sharing of stories. Stories that speak to the imbrication of settler-colonialism, lived histories of genocide, and the production of the “Native Other” in the settler-imaginary. They also model the ways that different languages, different forms, tell different stories and, perhaps more importantly, *tell stories differently*.

Stories are powerful. The stories that we believe, the stories that we *live into* shape our daily practices, from moment to moment. They have the power to promise some futures and conceal others. They encourage us to *see* some things and not others. Entrenched stories like “race,” “gender,” “class,” and “nation” have historically done this very well, prescribing who might accomplish what, where, when, and how. King underscores this when he reminds us that “we see race. Never mind that race is a construction and an illusion. Never mind that it does not exist in either biology or theology, though both have, from time to time, been enlisted in the cause of racism. Never mind that we can’t hear it or smell it or taste it or feel it. The important thing is that we believe we can see it” (2003, 44).

To call race a story, however, even when invited by King to do so, may cause some to pause. Right up front let me assure the reader that I am in no way suggesting, from my (Euro-settler) perspective, that race is a story to be taken lightly, or that the material, historical force of such stories can be shifted through sheer force of will. To say that *stories produce worlds* is not to say that changing stories is an easy practice, nor innocent, nor always possible. Stories, here, must be understood as productive of and produced by ideological worldviews with real-life consequences that, as Judith Butler (1988, 1990), among others, has taught us in the context of gender- and sexuality-based violence, require telling and retelling. The work of telling new stories, or new versions of stories that need retelling/recrafting, is propositional; it requires ongoing engagement and a willingness to denaturalize the social, disciplinary, ideological structures within which we are embedded (to speak *parrhesiastically*, as Foucault might have it).² King says as much in the afterword to his book, in his final repetition-with-a-difference: “*Want a different ethic? Tell a different story*” (60, 164; emphasis added).

Here, stories begin to have a weight they didn’t have before.

Stories such as race, class, gender, and nation are hegemonic; they are discursive practices that shape us ideologically and bodily and that come with violent (although not only violent) effects. And it is for this

reason that the central provocation of *The Truth about Stories* is that stories are “wondrous things. And they are *dangerous*” (King 2003, 9; emphasis added). Stories are wondrous in their capacity to reorganize our approaches to our social-material worlds; they are dangerous for their capacity to produce themselves as compelling objects of belief,³ naturalized, as all too many of us see year in and year out in the classroom, into calcified truths. Which is why King uses repetition—iteration, stories remaking stories, telling and retelling—to remind us that the telling of stories is a political performative. A world-making, knowledge-making practice.

One of the ways King does this is by opening and closing each of the five chapters of his lecture-text with the following repetitive structure: each chapter opens with someone, somewhere, in a dialogic setting, telling a version of a creation story in which the earth floats on the back of a turtle that is on the back of another turtle that is on the back of another turtle: “turtles all the way down” (2, 32, 62, 92, 122). This introductory story is followed in each case, word for word, by the following sentence, invoking the title of the book: “The truth about stories is that that’s all we are.” Each chapter then ends by reflecting back on the story told: “Take [X’s] story, for instance. It’s yours. Do with it what you will. . . . But don’t say in the years to come that you would have lived life differently if only you had heard this story. You’ve heard it now” (29, 60, 89, 119, 151).

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Through this repetitive narrative structure, King invites us to think about stories as material-semiotic events that impact—indeed, configure—worlds. He invites us to attend carefully to which stories *stick*; which stories, by performing themselves as compelling objects of belief—being convincingly *retold*—have the sticky staying power to change how one sees the world, and thus how one acts within it. Through repetition and direct address, King invites us to be attentive to which stories *we are crafted out of* as well as which we participate in crafting; which stories we teach, and which stories we are taught by.

Donna Haraway’s *The Companion Species Manifesto* makes a similar call for the power of stories. Haraway, a feminist theorist and science studies scholar, begins her book, published the same year as King’s, with the following: “I tell stories about stories, all the way down” (2003, 21).

The Companion Species Manifesto, like her 2007 *When Species Meet*, is a densely poetic and, for those not already familiar with her world of reference, sometimes frustratingly allusive text. Read with each other in mind, these two books of Haraway's can be seen to respond to similar questions, and although these questions are worded differently in each, the way that they are articulated in Haraway's later text—specifically, “Whom and what do I touch when I touch my dog?” and “How is ‘becoming with’ a practice of becoming worldly?” (2007, 3)—is key to both.

Whereas King focuses on the ear, on our capacity to be altered through ethical listening and speaking practices—forms of listening and speaking that render us response-able and, through this response-ability, able to be moved to act—Haraway asks us to attend to the material-semiotic stories we inherit when ethically touching—being in touch with—the world around us. For Haraway, we are always already “becoming-with” and imbricated by all that we touch and that touches us; what and how we touch and are touched by participates in constituting the stories, the worlds, within which we live.⁴ For King, the relation of storyteller to story-listener conditions which stories are whose to tell and when, producing stories not only as sites of knowledge but as ethical relations. One invites us to attend to how we are remade by all we speak and hear. One invites us to attend to how we are remade through all we touch and are touched by. Both frame these intertwined sensorial relations as productive of *stories that matter*.

Stories of the magnitude at stake here are never innocent. They always do certain things and not others; rely on certain things and not others. What King and Haraway ask, each in their own way, by mobilizing different stories in different ways, is that we seriously attend to and recognize the constitutive power of the stories through which we come to understand the world, and, when necessary, give our all to reorganize them. Importantly, within both King and Haraway's texts, it is *curiosity* that emerges as key to our capacity to make such changes.

Haraway's curiosity, in *The Companion Species Manifesto*, driven by her “companion” questions, pulls her into the telling of three stories in particular, each with its own narrative arc: first, a story of species-time (human-canine coevolution); second, a story of breed-time (the Australian Shepherd as an instrument of colonial expansion); third, a story of phenomenological-time (her specific agility training relations with Cay-

enne and Roland, two dogs with whom she was living and loving at the time of her writing). Haraway tells these three story-arcs as provocations that model her situated attempts to “cobble together” practices of living ethically *with* significant others, others with whom our differences emerge as significant—for example, the kinds of alien differences that emerge at the intersections between species (Haraway 2003, 7). Attentive to the histories and presents at stake when the question “Whom and what do I touch when I touch my dog?” is taken seriously, Haraway suggests that to “find arguments and stories that matter to the worlds we might yet live in” (3) we must investigate, with the curiosity of she-who-does-not-already-know, the material-semiotic entanglements, the “worldliness” out of which each of us, at any given moment, emerges.⁵ Curiosity, here, emerges as key to the political capacity of stories to remake worlds and is the kind of curiosity that also figures prominently *The Truth about Stories*.

Contrasting what he calls “scientific, capitalistic, Judeo-Christian” creation stories with “Native” creation stories (2003, 12), King tells his reader-listeners that “contained within creation stories are relationships that help define the nature of the universe and how cultures understand the world in which they exist” (10). One of the first of these stories is the story of Charm, who creates the world cooperatively with nonhuman others, almost, it seems, by accident. The story begins with Charm digging a hole so deep that she falls through it, and through space, until she lands on a Pangean version of Earth.⁶ She was warned of course (by Badger) not to dig too deep—not to be *too* curious. But she cannot help it. She digs and digs, her curiosity getting the better of her. That said, rather than a possessive division between “her” and “her curiosity,” the *driven* version of curiosity that King ascribes to Charm takes over her very sense of self such that her actions are no longer volitional but are constitutive: she doesn’t make them; *they make her*. And it is in this way that Charm’s curiosity becomes what King calls the “dangerous” kind (2003, 10–13)—the kind of curiosity that gets one into (methodological/ontological/epistemological/disciplinary) trouble.

It is just such a curiosity that, taught by Haraway and King, I would like to claim as central to the approach to research-creation for which this book argues.

King’s and Haraway’s perspectives, while speaking with seriousness to histories of genocide that have given us this world, can also be taken as

powerful invitations to attend to the ecologies of our pedagogical practices in the university, practices that structurally privilege certain modes of knowing, certain stories about knowledge production and dissemination, and not others. Standing on the shoulders of this assertion, what I suggested to my students in *Debates in Art and/as Research*, is that reading *The Companion Species Manifesto* and *The Truth about Stories* not only for their content, but for the worldviews that they model through the narrative and poetic forms that they mobilize, helps us to understand the power of stories as something that emerges not only at the level of content but that of *form*. Both authors implicitly insist that to do research—of any kind—is not simply to ask questions; it is to let our curiosities drive us and allow them to ethically bind us; it is to tell stories and to pay attention not only to which stories we are telling and *how* we are telling them, but how they, through *their very forms*, are *telling us*.

At the end of his book, echoing many a poststructuralist theorist, King draws on the words of poet and novelist Jeanette Winterson to assert that language is not something we speak; *it speaks us* (King 2003, 2). Languages (discourses) precede us; research methods and disciplines precede us. We enter into them and they work to craft the possible forms of our questions. Thus, when examining our research practices, it is crucial to ask: which stories are animating our choices? Why might this research choice *matter*? Alternate (research) stories create alternate (research) worlds. Conversely, different storytelling strategies (methods and practices) emerge from different worldviews and commitments. If we understand our research in the university as the production of a set of interlocking stories that are, indeed and ideally, world-changing fictions (Haraway [1985] 1991, 149)⁷—interventions, micro though any one intervention might be, into the givens that organize our social and material worlds—the next logical, research-creational, pedagogical, step is this: to open the university up not only to different *writerly vocalities*, as decades of feminist, literary, Indigenous, critical race, deconstructive, and performance studies (the list goes on) scholars have done, but also to different *tangible forms* (for example, a song, beadwork, a performance, or a video installation) as valid modes of rendering research public.⁸

It is with this in mind that I proposed to my students the following—slightly opaque—provocation as central to research-creation in its strong form: *the crafting of a research question is the crafting of a story that is also*

the crafting of an ethics. Following this, in a room full of students who self-identified as art historians and artists (along with a few sociologists and performance studies students), I, perhaps even more provocatively, proposed research-creation as a methodology that, therefore, *necessarily* side-steps disciplinary allegiance. That is, I suggested that rather than letting our research questions be conditioned by the structures of legibility and value given by, say, one's self-identifications as painter, or early modern art historian, or feminist theorist, we take seriously King's call to *tell stories differently* and pair this with our own versions of the questions that Haraway asks herself: "Whom and what do I touch when I touch my dog?" and "How is 'becoming with' a practice of becoming worldly?" (2007, 3).

Throughout the semester, "Haraway's dog" then became our touchstone for developing research approaches and orientations. Sometimes this appeared as a question from one student to another: "So . . . what is *your* dog?"; sometimes as a description within the classroom setting: "For my final project I've chosen 'desire lines on campus' as my dog; I'm asking: 'Whom and what do I traverse when I follow the desire lines across our campus fields?'" Together we discovered that to frame a research question in this way helped to unpin it from a primarily disciplinary orientation; to frame research in this way foregrounded the researcher's positionality and moved beyond primary accountability to a specific discipline while still keeping the door open to discipline-specific knowledges. Simply put, *it placed the curiosity-driven question first*.¹⁰ What these texts modeled for us was an approach to research rooted in process, multiplicity, context specificity, and contingency—one that might even be called *emergent*.

In *The Companion Species Manifesto*, Haraway writes: "The obligation is to ask who are present and who are *emergent*. . . . Situated emergence of more livable worlds depends on that differential sensibility" (50–51; emphasis added). This term—*emergent*—is peppered throughout *Companion Species*, and it is often paired with *symbiogenesis*. The terms rhyme conceptually. While *symbiogenesis*, forwarded by the evolutionary theorist Lynn Margulis ([1967] 1993), speaks to the relational origin of organisms (an understanding of the contested distinction *species* as emerging through symbiosis rather than mutation), *emergence* describes an aggregate property of elements, none of which demonstrate that property inherently within them. Water, in its liquid form, and snowflakes, as specific

crystallized forms, exhibit compound properties that are not seen at the (molecular) levels below. Water is emergent. So are snowflakes.

Emergence is relevant to research-creation not only because it is a recurring descriptor in writing on research-creation and its synonyms—which it is¹¹—but because it refigures disciplinary research objects in ways that invite us to think interdisciplinarity-as-emergence: as productive of outputs that exceed what is demonstrably present in their constituent parts. An approach to research modeled on emergence insists on the complexity of lived histories and worlds, and on the difficulty of accounting for and responding to such complexity.¹² It also insists on recognizing that this complexity is not simply a failure that adequate perspective—the capacity to somehow *see better*—might correct (what Haraway has called a *God trick* [1988, 582], the view of everything from nowhere), but rather that complexity is *the name of the game*, whether we are talking turtles (King 2003), elephants (Haraway 2003, 12), or metaplasms (54); it is “stories about stories, all the way down.”

The political practice of working with and through stories “all the way down,” of telling and retelling and weaving and reweaving, is far from politically neutral; it is also far from *affectively* neutral. In both the content and form of her text, Haraway models the “grain” of a research practice attentive to what I will call *love*. The love at stake, however, in the terms of Haraway’s text, is more akin to *eros* than *agape* (2003, 99). If *agape* figures a *knowing in general*—so-called unconditional love—*eros* figures something that is conditional (in the sense of being *situated*) and that is both critically unknown and unknowable (in the sense of being *emergent*): “Just who is at home must be permanently in question. The recognition that one cannot *know* the other or the self, but must ask in respect for all of time who and what are emerging in relationship, is the key” (50).

This distinction between *eros* and *agape* can be clarified further through one of Haraway’s key questions, which emerges toward the end of her *Companion Species*, as she reflects on the imperative of her guiding questions regarding whom and what she touches when she touches her dogs Roland and Cayenne. Haraway asks, “Beyond the personal, simple fact of joy in time and work with my dogs, why do I care? Indeed, in a world full of so many urgent ecological and political crises, *how* can I care?” (61). Understood at the level of *agape*, of love “in general,” Haraway’s love of her dogs is *apolitical*. If *eros* figures the love at stake, however, we are telling a

different story. In a way that I will expand on when we turn to the psychoanalytic frame of reference and the *objet petit a* in chapter four (and that echoes Audre Lorde's ([1984] 2007) work "The Uses of the Erotic: The Erotic as Power" to which I will also return), the *how* of Haraway's caring must be erotic in order for it to be ethical.

Haraway's book (as does King's, in a different idiom) implicitly argues that it is in allowing ourselves to be drawn by our loves, our intensive and extensive curiosities, attentive to what and whom we are *driven* to explore, and examining the complex web of relations that we inherit thereby, that we might inhabit research questions ethically. Ethics and eros, in this Aristotelian sense rather than a Freudian one,¹³ are inescapably intertwined, and this intertwining, this *chiasmus*, is crucial. As psychoanalysis teaches us, such "erotic" knowing is *always* partial and situated, always intertwined. Indeed, it is this partiality, this situatedness, this intertwining, that structures our (feminist) (research) stories as *accountable* (Haraway 1988). Within this paradigm, an ethical mode of accountability *needs* eros. Agape, in its unconditionality, its lack of situated attention-to-the-conditions-that-are-the-case, fails "to fulfill the messy conditions of being in love" (Haraway 2003, 35)—a love that is both driven and noninnocent.

It is only eros that can fulfill these messy conditions.

In other words, when in love-as-eros, the story is never told; it is always in the process of unfolding, and therefore always in need of new ways of accounting and rendering accountable. Haraway loves Roland and Cayenne. It is that love, and her need to take what she inherits with that love seriously, that guides her research in *Companion Species*. True love (eros) leads, as Haraway models for us, to true curiosity—to truly *driven* curiosity. The kind of curiosity that lends itself well to the "drive" that psychoanalysis thinks with; the kind of curiosity that can get one into trouble, and that forces one to try and figure out how, in Haraway's idiom, to *stay with* that trouble.¹⁴

At the heart of this book is the proposition that taking research-creation seriously, as a relatively new turn on the art-academic stage, gives those of us operating as artist-researchers/researcher-artists the opportunity to re-envision and re-craft—to re-story—our practices and labor, and, perhaps most importantly, our pedagogy, within university ecologies. As a full-time academic in the Canadian university system, it is my experience that one may be rewarded for being an artist-scholar, hired in studio

art, who does research-based work that takes artistic form. Similarly, one may be rewarded for being a scholar-artist, hired in art history, who does practice-led work that takes the form of academic writing (although this happens less often than the former). But to do both, simultaneously or sequentially, is, at best, to have half of one's labor demoted when it comes time for merit-based adjudication for pay increments or tenure; at worst, it is to be deemed a "dilettante."¹⁵

As I phrased it in the introduction, the struggle, here, is not for acknowledgment (a seat at the table: "Look! Now artists can be researchers too!" or vice versa). It is for the insertion of voices and practices that trouble the relays of knowledge/power that figure the disciplines impacted by any given research-creation practice. As part and parcel of questioning the stranglehold of disciplinary legibility on our practices in the university—as teachers, as researchers, as colleagues—today, we must attend to the ways that the disciplined university, with its merit boards and granting agencies structured to assess faculty outputs on the basis of contribution not to "new knowledge" *in general* but to new knowledge within *a discipline*, often renders those who would work *practicetheoretically*, attentive to King's ethics-producing stories and Haraway's curiosity-bound eros, both illegible and, in the most hostile of assessments, suspect. Research-creation, as an emergent, ethico-erotic form, allows us to tell new stories in new ways in the university landscape—stories that demand, in turn, new research literacies and outputs, modes of assessment and accountability, and new pedagogical modalities.¹⁶ Rather than allowing discipline to tell us what questions are worthwhile and what methods are appropriate, a research-creational approach insists that it is to our deepest, doggiest, most curious loves that we are beholden, and that it is love—eros—that must drive our research questions as well as our methodological toolkits.

In asserting this, I am in no way arguing against the value of disciplinary seriousness and care. Attention to disciplinary inheritance is crucial. Disciplinary attention and care, the *how* of doing things in certain contexts toward certain ends, matters, materially and politically. What I *am* suggesting, however, is that an ethical structure of research cannot, if we understand the ethics at stake here to be something expressed in the form of Haraway's love for her dog(s) or Charm in her digging, be given *first and foremost* by discipline.

Disciplinary approaches are, more often than not, organized by mor-

als and not ethics precisely to the degree that they think they know the parameters of the question and the appropriate form for the answer.¹⁷ Disciplines discipline us. Eros has no truck with such disciplining. To organize one's topic or method according to discipline may be pragmatic, and in many cases even necessary, and oftentimes incredibly useful, but not, on the psychoanalytic model I am taught by, *ethical*. Instead, a research-creational approach informed by King and Haraway insists on a multiplicity of responsive practices structured by situated (emergent, erotic, driven) accountability. While there are surely times when ethnography or discourse analysis or actor-network theory are the tools needed to get at what needs to be gotten to, research-creation, as a "problem-oriented" modality, puts situated curiosity—troubling and troublesome, erotic curiosity—at the helm.

Further, while research-creation can be understood as a mode of engagement allied with many interdisciplinary, curiosity-driven, problem-oriented approaches in the academy, given its grounding in artistic practices and methods, it also insists that artistic process and production be understood as transmissible knowledge with a ranked equivalence to the knowledge-making practices of other disciplines (Candlin 1998). That is, most commonly, it asserts a form of making that has traditionally been understood as expressive rather than analytically communicative (often, although not always, art making), as equivalent in value (though different in kind) to the knowledge-making practices of traditional academic disciplines.¹⁸ In this respect, research-creation is taught by the ways that feminism has dealt with the denigration of certain forms of work (maintenance and care work) and certain vocalities (the "personal voice"). It is taught this not only by feminism, but by Indigenous, decolonial, and antiracist scholarship challenging institutional structures and intellectual traditions that draw their power from seeing certain kinds of research as nonresearch.¹⁹

I think here of works like Leanne Betasamosake Simpson's (2013) *Islands of Decolonial Love* and Audre Lorde's ([1984] 2007) *Sister Outsider*. Each of these texts is made up of interconnected fragments: Simpson's is a collection of poignant stories that make palpable the different worlds made by Native and settler stories in (what is now called) Canada; Lorde's is a collection of essays tracking her experience of histories of systemic, localized oppression on the basis of race, gender, and sexuality in (what is now called) the United States. Both are calls to consciousness. And

in them, the personal takes many forms. It takes the form of Simpson's pointed storytelling; it takes the form of Lorde's passionate first-person address. Both texts leap off the page, inviting us to think carefully about which stories we are telling, why, and *how*, in the university today.²⁰

The *how*, here, is crucial.

As I have been claiming it, research-creation, at its most interesting, emerges when the modes of interdisciplinarity that have become common to the early twenty-first-century university (the bringing together of different methodological literacies that illuminate new ways of thinking and doing relevant to a pressing problem but that results in a single species of output, for example, a book) shift to allow for the bringing together not only of different methodological literacies but of different species of output (a book and a video or an essay and a performance) that, while dissonant in terms of their language, are understood to have *equally weighted value* as objects of knowledge production and impact within university communities and their assessment rubrics. Such work, while crossing "practice-theory" lines in the literacies that it mobilizes, does not result in *either* a written essay *or* an exhibition, but insists on the "double-headedness" of multiple, equally weighted, output forms, and has impact at the methodological level for practitioners, at the assessment level for institutions, and at the dissemination level for both. These distinctions are key.

While, for example, artistic works such as conceptual artist Mary Kelly's *Post-Partum Document* (1973–79) or academic ones such as anthropologist Natasha Myers's "Anthropologist as Transducer in a Field of Affects" (forthcoming) model an interdisciplinary approach to practice and theory that has relevance for research-creation, because of the weighted values of these outputs they are not generally understood as research-creation strictly speaking. Kelly's *Post-Partum Document* is a conceptual and research-based art installation that tracks and analyzes Kelly's first six years of motherhood through a Lacanian developmental lens. It takes the form of found object and text panels paired with psychoanalytic text panels (139 pieces in total). It also takes the form of a book that includes theoretical essays and art-historical reflection.²¹ Myers's "Anthropologist as Transducer in a Field of Affects" is an academic essay that mobilizes dance literacies, daily-practice performance art, and drawing to develop new tools for ethnographic analysis. Importantly, Myers's writing does not explicate the creative practice or process as an equally weighted

mode of rendering public the research, but, rather, describes its use as a methodological tool for transforming the field of anthropology.²² Both of these projects have something to offer to an expanded understanding of research-creation in an interdisciplinary context. However, as representative examples, they help show how relations of “practice” to “theory” can be made to resolve quite easily into legible disciplinary identities—a work of research-based conceptual art (Kelly) and an innovative anthropological essay (Myers) without in any way diminishing their brilliance.²³ Here, “Anthropologist as Transducer in a Field of Affects” and *Post-Partum Document* emerge as relevant for but not exemplary of research-creation due to the fact that, while each work succeeds in interweaving “practice” and “theory,” one side of the binary is understood as support/developmental or conceptual material for the other. An “exemplary” research-creation practice resists this hierarchy in the context of the academy, rerouting our disciplinary orientations in such a way as to allow both forms of output to hold equal professional weight.

This latter is what Simon Penny (2009) calls *deep interdisciplinarity*.²⁴ Penny distinguishes deep interdisciplinarity thus: “[What is at stake is] the formation of practitioners who are neither artists nor engineers, [but] who are equal parts both” (2009, 33). In alliance with Penny, the mode of research-creation argued for in this book works from the premise that interdisciplinarity requires being attentive to disciplinarily “othering” habits that privilege either artistic *or* technoscientific *or* social scientific *or* humanities-based habits of thought and dissemination. Further, to be both *equally* and *responsively* weighted between practice and theory means not only that written components and artistic components are structured as equally-weighted-thought-differentially-vocalized research outputs, but that the very forms of each must be made responsive to the research at stake. If robust interdisciplinarity asks that one start with a research question and then bring together the disciplines most useful for addressing that question, research-creation pushes this one step further, asking: what output forms—modes of publication—might most interestingly and generatively render that research public?²⁵ As Roland Barthes wrote in 1972, “in order to do interdisciplinary work, it is not enough to take a ‘subject’ (a theme) and to arrange two or three sciences around it. Interdisciplinary study consists of creating a new object, which belongs to no one” (72).

Belonging to no one, research-creational outputs, in this context, might

be productively understood as what Geoffrey Bowker and Susan Leigh Star (1999) call *boundary objects*. Bowker and Star define boundary objects as “those objects that both inhabit several communities of practice and satisfy the informational requirements of each of them. Boundary objects are thus both plastic enough to adapt to the local needs and constraints of the several parties employing them, yet robust enough to maintain a common identity across sites. They are weakly structured in common use and become strongly structured in individual-site use. . . . These objects may be abstract or concrete . . . but their structure is common enough to more than one world to make them recognizable, a means of translation” (297). If disciplines articulate themselves by laying claim to specific research objects, methods, modes of attention, questions, and lineages of discourse, what a boundary object does is create something like an *uncanny* tie across disciplines, retaining a certain amount of internal coherence while denaturalizing methodologies and analyses endemic to different disciplinary locations. A boundary object *does things with disciplines*, satisfying certain of their requirements, without, however, belonging properly to any one of them.

Owen Chapman’s 2015 *Alphabet Radio* provides a useful example for thinking through the relationship between Bowker and Star’s understanding of the boundary object and my arguments regarding research-creation. Chapman, an associate professor in the Department of Communication Studies at Concordia University in Montreal, describes *Alphabet Radio* thus:

Alphabet Radio is one part of a larger project called *Audio Toy Box*. A handmade interactive electronic device made out of cardboard, it responds to decks of specialized cards featuring images, symbols, icons, colours, and other visual cues. Each card has an embedded RFID chip that causes a unique sound to playback when the card is presented to the integrated RFID reader. These sounds, related to the featured images, include words, syllables, phonetic sounds, musical elements and other short audio files—each crafted with specific pedagogical/therapeutic goals in mind. Sounds are stored on easy to switch SD memory chips (commonly used in digital cameras). Different sets of memory chips along with different decks of cards allow a user to create tailor-made, repetitive, audio play/learning experiences.

The project is driven by a strong familial love. My daughter was diagnosed with “global developmental delays” when she was quite young. The larger *Audio Toy Box* project (of which *Alphabet Radio* is one component) comes out of my desire to create new, more creative and engaging, ways of living and working with these so-called delays and seeks to present alternative frameworks for developing and sharing non-ableist, affordable and adaptable/customizable pedagogical toy designs. The project approaches the study of disability from an artistic and interdisciplinary perspective and questions cultural narratives and discourses that posit disability as inherently tragic for individuals and families.²⁶

Alphabet Radio is a Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council-funded research-creation project. It functions as a DIY social-art intervention, a maker-lab object, and a pedagogical tool in critical disability studies contexts. As Chapman conceives of it, it is all of these things at once, and properly none of them. I’d like to suggest that what allows *Alphabet Radio* to function as a boundary object not solely claimable by any one context is that, while remaining legible to a number of disciplinary sites, it fails to *fully* fulfill the criteria of any one disciplinary location. In some ways, it is an *in-coherent* object. That is, *Alphabet Radio* speaks well enough to each disciplinary context to be legible and meaningful, without fitting *so well* as to be naturalized within any of them.

This is compounded by the fact that *Alphabet Radio* is but one element of Chapman’s larger *Audio Toy Box* project. *Audio Toy Box* adds into the mix the production of academic writing and the desire to contribute to both the disciplines of communications studies and interdisciplinary field of critical disability studies, as well as artistic, designerly, and activist sites. *Audio Toy Box* has outputs that are academic, outputs that are artistic, and outputs that are activist, and each of these sets of research outputs are (designed to be) weighted equally, with the research question itself hovering between them, and addressed and cared for differently by each of them. The project is not built to circulate in the art world, nor the world of marketable pedagogical disability aids, nor to embody the gadget-gear-cool-factor badge of maker-lab circulation, nor the university. It promiscuously inhabits all of these spaces, speaking to each, resisting being fully claimed by any one disciplinary location while being nonethe-



FIGURE 1.1 — Owen Chapman, *Alphabet Radio*, 2015. Photo courtesy of the artist.

less legible across all of them. Holding its own as a research-creational object that denaturalizes the givens of each of the disciplinary spaces at stake, it places curiosity, desire, and love at the helm.

Another example we could turn to in this context is artist and academic Beatriz da Costa's *Pigeonblog* (2006–8).²⁷ Part art-as-social-practice/new-genre public art, part academic intervention, part citizen science, and part activism, *Pigeonblog* is a multimodal project that, at its core, functions as a speculative proposition: What if we all worked in minimally invasive ways to generate local knowledge, collaboratively, in our communities, on complex issues related to social and climate justice? What kinds of worlds might we be able to generate by cultivating more grassroots, creative, accessible relationships to technoscientific knowledge production? And what role might art play in such reworldings?

Pigeonblog was developed specifically to track air quality in local neighborhoods and visualize the information gathered online and in exhibition (see da Costa n.d.). For the project, da Costa (in collaboration with her ACE grad students at the University of California, Irvine, Cina Hazegh and Kevin Ponto) used custom-built miniature air pollution-sensing devices, working with the pigeons and their fanciers over many months to develop a pack the pigeons would agree to fly (Haraway 2016, 20–24). These packs enabled the pigeons to send air-quality information in real time to an online server, which was then translated into a visualization schema using a Google map of the area the pigeons were flying through.

Like Chapman's *Audio Toy Box*, *Pigeonblog* was “published” in multiple forms—public performance, gallery exhibition, and written text—with each of these publication modes holding equal weight. It required that da Costa perform as artist, legible within the field of art-as-social-practice; as engineer, working collaboratively on microelectronics with other engineers; as a theorist of what da Costa framed as *tactical biopolitics*;²⁸ and as social justice activist attentive to multispecies relations and ethics. As da Costa writes in her project statement “Interspecies Coproduction in the Pursuit of Resistant Action,” “*Pigeonblog* attempted to start a discussion about possible new forms of co-habitation in our changing urban ecologies and made visible an already existing world of human-pigeon interaction. At a time where species boundaries are being actively reconstructed on the molecular level, a re-investigation of human to non-human animal relationships is necessary.”²⁹ This call for ecological and technoscientific



FIGURE 1.2 — Beatriz da Costa, *Pigeonblog*, 2006–8. PHOTO COURTESY OF ROBERT NIDEFFER.

justice lies at the core of this and much, if not all, of da Costa's work. Her work models a research-creational approach to multispecies ethics and pedagogy that speaks across academic and nonacademic divides, one that uses artistic forms as spectacular lures and mobilizers of affect and action.

Research-creation, as modeled by Chapman and da Costa, is a particular kind of curiosity-driven, inter- or transdisciplinary method, a method that learns from the interdisciplinary humanities, but that adds to these debates by crossing "practice" and "theory" lines in ways that, like Krauss's expanded field, tumbles outside of our attempts to contain them, and that demands new literacies (indeed, taught by Krauss we could argue for research-creation as something that hovers ambivalently between "art and not-art" and "research and not-research"). To do research-creation in this way is to produce objects that work not only across discursive fields but challenge the norms of those fields, producing boundary objects that insist on being undutiful.³⁰ Pointing to the ways that disciplinary knowledge claims ("sorting things out") always highlight certain elements while masking others, research-creation, thus figured, insists that curiosity, in all its erotic pluripotency, be its guide, pushing us to tell new stories in the academy, stories that denaturalize singular disciplinary locations while nomadically claiming space within all of them;³¹ stories that unmake as much as they remake how we understand what we are doing as *maker-thinkers* in the—disciplined and disciplining—university today.